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Homework #3 – Ignoring Warnings

There are many examples of software failures where the user or software had been warned prior to the failure. This essay will discuss three cases of warnings being ignored, which resulted in software or system failures. The first example will be the Therac-25 incident, where six patients were killed. The second example will be Joshua Brown Tesla Incident, where Joshua Brown was killed by colliding into a tractor-trailer. The final example not included in the book will be the most famous example of warnings being ignored, the Sinking of The Titanic.

The Therac-25 incident happened because they imported old software into new hardware, reduced the protective hardware, and operators ignored warning signs. This machine was designed to give detailed pictures, and attack cancer growth, however due to the Therac-25 not having the hardware safety that Therac-20 did, it malfunctioned and overdosed 6 patients. The issue was that the system fully relied on the software to be completely correct, and the software had major bugs in it. They did not find the bugs in the code because the older Therac-20 had more hardware that protected against the bugs, but in the new Therac-25 they wanted to reduce costs, so they cut hardware and let the software do all the work with bugs. The operators were given warnings many times, such as “Malfunction 54”, which they ignored

because they could not understand them and were given no explanation. Overall, this situation was avoidable by listening to warnings.

The second example of ignoring warnings would be the Joshua Brown Tesla Autopilot Incident. Within this situation two cars collided, the Tesla and a white tractor-trailer, killing Mr. Brown. Prior to deployment of the Tesla cars the developers had gotten warnings while testing them and decided to ship the cars out with clear issues in the autopilot system. The issue is that the autopilot picked up the trailers as overhead signs, giving the system no warnings. What happened in this situation was due to the color, trailer, and angle the autopilot didn't register the truck as there until the last second. During Mr. Brown's drive, however, he was given many warnings to pay attention to the road, and he also went around ten miles over the speed limit. This situation had multiple parties ignoring multiple different warning signs, which lead to the tragic death of a man.

While the Titanic was not caused by software issues, it was caused by ignoring warning signs, and it is a pivotal story in history. The Titanic was considered the ship "practically unsinkable", which was later proven wrong on its first voyage, crashing into an iceberg sinking the ship. The captain of the Titanic, Edward Smith, was warned many times over radio by neighboring ships such as the *SS Californian*. The captain ignored all warnings of icebergs, and ice, which lead him into sailing straight into an iceberg which sunk the ship and killed many people. Overall this shows that people have been ignoring warnings for many years, and even a long time before software or computers.

To conclude, there have been many unfortunate events that were caused by ignoring warnings signs. The first two examples were software related warnings and failures, both caused by user ignored signs, and lazily designed products. The last example while is not an ignored software warning, this is an example of an ignored warning, showing that people have done this for hundreds of years, and in the modern day it is just better documented. Overall ignoring warnings has been a major issue in human history past and present.

Citations

Michael J. Quinn Ethics for the Information Age (9th edition)

Wikimedia Foundation. (2026, April 20). Sinking of the Titanic. Wikipedia.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sinking_of_the_Titanic